

INKJET MFDS

Inkjet MFDs are very popular today, especially because of ever-falling prices. Nothing of significance happened in this field in 2007, but certain technological advancements such as faster printing technology using a head that does not need to move are in the pipeline, and are expected to go mainstream this year.

HOME INKJET MFDS

The Reigning Champion Canon PIXMA MP160

An entry-level inkjet MFD based on 4-cartridge thermal inkjet printing technology. Having four separate cartridges is advantageous because if one of the cartridges gets drained, you can replace just that, as opposed to having to replace a combined colour cartridge. This MFD has a 7-segment LCD display that shows the selected number of copies to be printed.

The Contender HP Photosmart C3188 All-in-One

An inkjet photo MFD based on 2-cartridge thermal inkjet printing technology, this one has an input tray capacity of 100 sheets—good for most SoHo purposes. The scanner's optical resolution is 1200 x 2400 dpi—the best in the category. Being a proper photo MFD, it has buttons to Reprint photos as well as proof sheets. Interestingly, it features memory card slots but not PictBridge. Photo print quality was excellent, second only to that of the Reigning Champion. This MFD was neck-and-neck with the champion—even the price is the same—but it lost out a little on performance.

The Award Canon PIXMA MP160

The Canon PIXMA MP160 prints really fast—it printed the normal-quality text document in 9.3 seconds flat. It was also the fastest at printing our combi-document at Normal quality. It printed exceptionally well even at the highest speeds. The edges of the text were crisp, and the ink did not blot the paper even at high quality.

The copy quality was the best in the

category, and this MFD scored the highest even in our scanner test. Though priced a little on the higher side, at Rs 5,999, its exceptionally good performance fetches the Canon PIXMA MP160 the Zero1 award in this category.

OFFICE INKJET MFDS

The Reigning Champion HP Photosmart C4188 All-in-One

Good looks, good prints, and great build quality—good enough to bear the rigours of office use. Based on thermal inkjet printing technology, it uses two cartridges. This photo printer has memory slots for SD, MS, MS Pro, SM, MMC, and xD, and it also supports PictBridge. There is also a Reprint function and a special side tray to store 4 x 6 photo papers. The C4188 has the Photo Fix function, which lets you apply effects to images read from memory cards so you can improve print quality.

The Contenders Canon PIXMA MP460

Now this MFD exhibited the best performance in every department. It was clearly the fastest in printing, and without a doubt had the best photo print quality despite the fast speeds. It produced clear prints in true-to-original colours. It was fast at the text and combi-documents as well. The copy quality was so good, it was hard for us to distinguish between the original and its copy! A swivel colour LCD lets you not only view the photo from a memory card or camera connected to the PictBridge port, but also crop and resize it. However, this MFD costs almost 2000 rupees more than the Reigning Champion.

The Award HP Photosmart C4188 All-in-One

The HP Photosmart C4188 All-in-One (Rs 7,999) featured high-resolution scanning at 1200 x 2400 dpi, which means it picks up even text in



fine print from hardcopies. It was the fastest in black text printing at Normal quality. It was also a clear winner in the photo prints, reproducing natural colours. This is a clear winner of a Zero1 award.



LASER MFDS

Laser MFDs are good for any business, but especially for a growing one. They are best used when the workload involves high-volume, high-speed printing, and one that needs to be very cost-effective. They are more expensive than inkjets, but the extra cash is quickly recovered as you print more and more, owing to the low printing cost.

BUDGET (UP TO RS 16,000)

The Reigning Champion Brother DCP-7010

This is a compact MFD with a footprint of just 43.2 x 39.5 cm² (which is quite small). The DCP-7010 is a mono laser printer, scanner, and copier. It has a hardware print resolution of 2400 x 600 dpi, which is quite high for an entry-level product. Scanner resolution is 600 x 2400 at 24-bit resolution, and it supports a maximum paper size of A4. Along with the USB interface, there is also the older parallel interface for working with legacy devices.

The Contender HP LaserJet M1005 MFP

This entry-level machine from HP rivals the DCP-7010 in all respects, and surpasses it in some. The performance is traditional HP: good speeds and excellent print quality. The scanner works reliably and has support for resolutions for all purposes. At Rs 12,999, it is priced at a premium, but given the availability of consumables and other value-added services, it's well worth the money.

The Award Brother DCP-7010

The Brother DCP-7010 wins our Zero1 award. Print quality was average for text in Draft mode, but improved a lot in Best mode. The scanner reproduced colours fairly well; in fact, it's good enough for photographs. The bundled MFL-Pro suite—a control centre to take care of jobs such as scanning, faxing, and more—is good, and also bundled is PaperPort 9.0SE (OCR software). The DCP-7010 is decently priced (Rs 11,150); the toner cartridge costs



Rs 2,150, meaning the cost per print is 86 paise. We'd still recommend this MFD because of portability, speed, and overall performance.

SOHO (RS 16,001–RS 30,000)

The Reigning Champion Brother MFC-7420

With a rather small footprint of just 43.2 x 39.5 cm², it's easy to set up this device just about anywhere. It has fax functionality and an ADF tray that holds 35 sheets. It is built fairly well, except the flaps don't seem sturdy. The input tray has a capacity of 250, sufficient for most SoHos, while the output tray holds 100 sheets—again, not bad. The fax has a memory of 500 pages, so you'll probably never miss a fax. This unit features the USB as well as the parallel port interfaces, and although it does not come with an Ethernet port, you have the option of separately purchasing an Ethernet Print Server.

The Contenders Canon imageCLASS MF4122

The MF4122 has a small footprint and is built very well. It has an input tray capacity of 250 sheets—pretty good. There is also a multipurpose tray that holds one sheet. It is amazing that even though it doesn't cost too much, it features duplex printing. A Toner Gauge button lets you monitor the amount of toner remaining. Warm-up time was just 7.4 seconds, the fastest we've ever recorded for a laser MFD. Print quality was good, and so was copying speed and quality. It comes with OmniPage SE OCR and Presto! PageManager.

The Award Brother MFC-7420



The software bundled with the Brother MFC-7420—our Zero1 award winner—comprises the MFL-Pro suite with PaperPort 9.0SE OCR, and also a utility to set up the unit over a network. The MFC-7420 has a toner duty cycle of 3,500, making for an economical cost per page of 61 paise. Rs 18,000 for this model is justified because of the fax, ADF, and sheet-fed scanner.